Alexander 9.1 — What's New

Nov 7, 2026 · @ai masters

Overview

Alexander 9.1 is a live book release on top of Alexander 9. The search, the evaluation, Handicap mode, the avatars and The Master's Verdict are the same: the bench signature is still 3905509 nodes.

It adds the **LiveBook Width** option, so that the live books stop repeating the same move, and fixes crashes and wrong moves of the live books and the online tablebases.

It also adds the **Show Experience** button and fixes the persisted learning: Off now works without a restart, and changing Persisted learning or Experience Book no longer loses what was learned.

New: LiveBook Width

Until 9 the live books always played their top move, even when other moves were just as good. **LiveBook Width** (1–20, default 1) works like **Book N Width** of the CTG/BIN books: the engine picks at random, with the same probability, among the best move and up to Width − 1 moves equivalent to it.

Source	Equivalent moves	Order of the moves
ChessDB	The moves ChessDB ranks best (`!`, rank 2): a few centipawns from the best one at most	ChessDB score
Lichess Masters, Games, Player	Same Shashin zone of the success rate (wins + draws / 2 for the side to move) as the best move, and played in at least 0.5% of the games, as for the BIN books	Wins, then draws
Proxy	The proxy sends a single move (use LiveBook Proxy Diversity for variety)	—
Lichess and ChessDB tablebases	None: always the best move	Order of the server

With the avatars this gives the variety of a real repertoire. **LiveBook Lichess Player** with a width above 1 alternates the lines of that player that score in the same Shashin zone, instead of repeating the most played one. **LiveBook Lichess Games** already follows the rating band of Handicap mode, and now varies within it too. With width 1 nothing changes: the best move is played, as before.

New: Show Experience

Show Experience is a new button among the UCI options: it lists in the GUI the experience of the current position, the one of the last `position` command, as the console command `showexp` does. For example, after two searches of the initial position and a game opened with 1.Nf3:

```
info string Experience file: /engines/Alexander/experience.exp, 3 entries in
memory
info string Experience for the current position:
rnbqkbnr/pppppppp/8/8/8/8/PPPPPPPP/RNBQKBNR w KQkq - 0 1
info string   e2e4 depth 16 value 22 (cp 8) win probability 51%
info string   d2d4 depth 15 value 25 (cp 9) win probability 51%
info string   g1f3 played, not searched
```

- **Experience file**: the file the engine reads, next to the executable, marked *(not found)* if it does not exist yet, and the entries in memory.
- **Moves**: in the order of the Experience Book (depth, then win probability, then score), each with its depth, its value in internal units as in the file, the score in centipawns or mate as in the analysis, and its win probability. Only the moves legal in the position are listed.
- **Played, not searched**: a move of the game in progress that the engine never searched. It is not saved.
- **Learning Off**: with Persisted learning Off and Experience Book on, a line says that nothing is learned or written. With both off the experience file is not loaded, and the button says so.

Arena and Shredder show these lines in their engine window. The ChessBase GUIs do not show info strings: set **Debug Log File** and read them in the log.

New and changed options

Option	Type, default	What changes in 9.1
LiveBook Width	Integer 1–20, default 1	New: random choice among the best move and the equivalent ones (see above)
LiveBook Timeout	Integer 100–60000 ms, default 5000	A request also never takes more than half of the optimum time of the move
ChessDB Tablebase, Lichess Tablebase	Check, default false	Used whenever the Syzygy tablebases cannot probe the position, also with a SyzygyPath set
LiveBook Depth	Integer 1–255 plies, default 255	Unchanged; with at most 7 pieces the opening live books are no longer queried
Show Experience	Button	New: lists in the GUI the experience of the current position (see above)
Persisted learning	Combo Off/Standard/Self, default Off	Off now applies at once; a change saves the experience before reloading it
Experience Book	Check, default false	A change saves the experience before reloading it; with Persisted learning on, nothing is reloaded

Bug fixes

- **Crash on ChessDB**: an answer with an unknown score (`score:??`), possible in tablebase positions, stopped the engine.
- **ChessDB tablebase moves**: the `egtb:` moves sent by a proxy (query and querybest) were ignored; now they are played.
- **go depth and go nodes**: the live books answered and the engine played without searching. Now they follow the rules of the CTG/BIN books; when pondering they still work, and on a ponderhit the book move comes at once.

- **Endgames up to 7 pieces**: with a SyzygyPath set, the opening live books were queried and the online tablebases skipped, even with missing or smaller tablebase files. Now the online tablebases are used whenever the Syzygy tablebases cannot probe the position.
- **Time**: a slow or hanging server could cost the game on time. A request now takes at most half of the optimum time of the move, and the HTTP connection is reused between requests.
- **go searchmoves**: a CTG/BIN or experience book move outside searchmoves made the engine play an unsearched move. Now it searches.
- **Large Lichess counts**: the totals of the explorer are summed in 64 bits.
- **Build**: incremental builds could mix objects compiled with different versions of the live book classes.

Persisted learning fixes

- **Off ignored**: switching Persisted learning back to Off without restarting did nothing: the engine kept learning, reading and writing experience.exp, until it was restarted. Now Off applies at once.
- **Learning lost on option changes**: changing Persisted learning or Experience Book reloaded the experience file and discarded everything learned since the last save. Now the experience is saved first, unless Read only learning is on. Leaving Self in the middle of a game saves what was learned in that game, as `quit` does. With Persisted learning on, Experience Book no longer reloads the file, already in memory.
- **Failed saves**: when the new file could not be written completely (disk full, no permission), experience.exp was deleted anyway and the experience was lost. Now the old file stays, and an info string says that the experience was not saved.
- **Empty experience file**: an experience.exp of 0 bytes, written when no move had been searched, was read past its end at the next start. Now it counts as an empty experience.
- **Recovery file**: experience_new.exp, left by an interrupted save, was looked for in the working folder instead of the engine folder, so with some GUIs it was not recovered and was then overwritten. Now it is read from the engine folder, like experience.exp; `quickresetexp` reads from there too.
- **Memory**: every `position` command allocated again all the moves of the game, so with learning on the memory grew for the whole session. Now only new moves take memory.
- **File content**: the 2 padding bytes of each entry were written with whatever was in memory. Now they are 0: the format does not change, and the same experience gives the same file.

Upgrade notes

1. With the default options Alexander 9.1 plays like 9: LiveBook Width is 1 and the search is unchanged.
2. The Lichess live books still need **LiveBook Lichess Token**, created at lichess.org/account/oauth/token without any scope.
3. The live books are no longer used with `go depth` and `go nodes`. With at most 7 pieces they give way to the local Syzygy tablebases when these can probe the position.
4. With very little time (an optimum under about 200 ms per move) the live books are skipped, so that a request cannot cost the game on time.
5. The experience files of Alexander 9 are read and written as before. Changing **Persisted learning** or **Experience Book** now writes experience.exp, unless **Read only learning** is on.